

The Forbidden City

Commissioned by the Ming emperor Chang Zu (1360–1424), and built in 1406–20, the Forbidden City served as the Chinese Imperial Palace for nearly 500 years. The 980-building complex comprised audience halls, residences and courtyards on 7.2 hectares (18 acres) protected by a high wall and a moat, and entry was strictly by imperial permission. Not seeking to build lasting monuments, the Chinese constructed buildings reflecting the opposing forces of yin and yang, and they focused on the relationship of buildings to each other and to the landscape. Most buildings are made of wood, marble and specially baked bricks from Suzhou, with overhanging roofs supported on beams, posts and brackets. Laid out on a grid with a north–south axis, buildings were typically decorated with colourful glazed tiles and dragons, with yellow roofs symbolizing respect. Buildings include the halls of Supreme Harmony and Central Harmony, and palaces of Heavenly Purity and Earthly Tranquillity. Five marble bridges spanned the River of Golden Water that meanders through the city.

